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The writer, the instrument and the observer

April 2026, MFA at Konstfack

This essay is set up in three different chapters: the writer, the instrument, and the observer. Each part is meant to reflect upon its title themes with different voices and different methods of writing. Longer, more academic reflections are mixed with highly personal, almost journal entry-like sections. The structure is a reflection on how one needs to write in different styles in order to capture and write about these fragile and sometimes ephemeral themes.

I. **The writer** uses notes taken during the writing of this essay combined with typed text from as far back as 2022. During this chapter I mention how Moyra Davey's book Index cards was the primary reference in how this essay structure came about.
II. **The instrument** goes into artistic research and the what, whys and hows of the practice, balanced with references to Malcom Gladwell's thin slicing as well as Liv Bugge's active listening.
III. Finally, we have **The Observer**, a chapter around object permanence, the observer effect and superposition. This part explains the central theories that surround the works and reflects on how our observation curates our world and how noting the lack of knowledge within our observation might be both scary and beneficial.

The writer

Let's set the stage. Here is where you are, this is what you observe, this is your reality.

On screen, two children approximately one and five years old, playing and posing in front of a mirror in a hallway. The older child call out:
"Sara look at the camera, look at mom, that direction, that's where you should look"
The child briefly turns and faces us. In the lower right corner we read: 19 of January 1996.

17 Oct 2022
Time of birth 19:46

A slow moving leash pulls me
we run in circles
you pull I bark
I bark

7 Oct 2024
Creating a structure
creating a space “setting the stage” for something to occur.

Simple, neutral space for understanding difficult theories
structuring for my sake and to put things into perspective

structure, capture, archive, sort, enclose, keep
“put the things in a box and stored it away in the brain”

Pattern recognition
Superposition,
Rumsfeld matrix
an entity made to observe certain things can only observe those things.

31 Jan 2025
i[redacted],
the topic:? pointing out that there is more
than the observable universe

how?[redacted]However it
can be positioned to an audience, which is
A clear struggle. medium? Installations,
sound, text, performance, radio shows, collecting
objects, where I feel that they hold more than the
visual impact, objects that physically or psychologically
bring me something. There tends to be a nostalgic
collection. A focus on older or natural objects.
Perhaps for their ability to be outside my timeline,
perhaps some objects for the emotional connection.
[redacted] The visual is not at the forefront of the
practice, yet that is what an audience sees…
The practice is about what’s outside
[redacted] the observable, what is outside the observer.

24 February
Place a camera down in front of a mirror, press record. The camera is filming into the mirror. I move my hand in front, it is visible both in the mirror and the camera. I pull my hand back slightly, it is now only visible in the mirror, I pull back even more, it is now only visible to my eyes. I put it out in front of the camera again, it is now visible to the camera in the camera viewer, in the mirror and in through my eyes. But which hand is more real?

There is nothing faster than the speed of light. It takes roughly 9 minutes for the sun's rays to hit earth. Even on a smaller scale it takes some milliseconds for light to travel from an object to your eye after opening. The object's mirror image, the light exists in your eye and hence in your brain. If we were to place ten people around a flower, all at different lengths and angles. Doesn't the flower actually exist in ten places at once or none? How can we know for certain that the object of that flower is still the same as it is in our eyes? It takes time for it to reach us therefore we are always seeing a past version of an object, even if it's only within milliseconds.

3 March
There is still a garland hanging from the red picket fences surrounding the tiny bakery where we have sat down. The smell of horse manure is palpable. My fingers itch from the cold but the want for those first spring rays are bigger than the need for heat. A plane goes overhead, a vogue is lit, a saw spins. Spring always makes me feel anxious; it's the movement from a slower lifestyle indoors to a hectic scream of birds and human hands. It's the movement from one thing to the other, like stretching your skin as you grow thicker hips and longer legs.

For two days straight I've opened Moyra Davey book *Index cards*[1] and noticed myself straight away in a deep need to write, both times I stopped myself, allowing Davey's text to stay on the pages instead of coming out from my fingertips. It's her way of noting down thoughts, experiences as well as reflective analysis on theories and artists such as Barthes, Sontag and Benjamin (names so stuck in the art world it's hard to get away from them) that inspire. This mix of rational and sometimes irrational thoughts combined finds me at the right time. I jot down books to read as Davey continues her reflections and her takes on Nostalgia, yes, yes, I get it. A saturated word with an emphasis on dark colors and high contrasts. It's present in my work, yes. Not as much as you might think. Actually I am not certain yet as to what nostalgia actually is. A feeling, a notion of the past, a longing for "other", seeking shelter in my less complicated past and feeling the ache of the present. Perhaps that is nostalgia, perhaps only a disability of the mind. I move on, put the book down and run to get my fingers onto the

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[1] *Davey, M. (2020). Index cards. Fitzcarraldo Editions.*

keyboard inspired and intrigued.

4 March

This need for citation is bugging me. I am not an avid reader, unfortunately, more so I listen, books, podcasts, what have you. To add to that I am also terrible at remembering names. Pierre Huyghe is mentioned, I say I don't know him, re-read his name and then with an aha say “he did the work with the dog that's called human[2], with the pink leg” what my memory remembers are the beehives, compost, flowers and most of all the name of the dog, yet no name of the artist. I wonder how I can cite the sources of my life. How can one put footnotes on tiktok sounds saved to a folder? Or the feeling of a newly brushed asphalt street? The smell, the touch, the sight, the hearing. The strength in a feeling? Emptied out bowels onto a therapist desk whilst getting rewarded with coffee? Tuva and Alva say thank you, see you in two weeks. I blame Davey for her use of a Dr and of citations. I might come back to it later. Disability is present as well as aphantasia. I see nothing and what I do experience is not all that saturated. The memory instead stays in the feeling. I tend to start sentences with “I”. A tendency that I am in the process of trying to remove. But how can one be more specific, less personal and share stories without the I? Without me? It is impossible and so we move on. I pop two propiomazin for sleep as I remember the person in therapy mentioning lithium today and can't help but hear Kurt's voice [3].

13 March

At 10:26 I stepped out of the apartment, one bag strung on my shoulder. Handsfree, except the clasp of my phone. I want to have time to pass through the crowds and arrive at my destination in time.

There might be tension in the words that are written but I have nothing left to gain in this kind of system. Systematic undoing is the new normal, the new hot normality. Sexy even. Craving that sultry look from the mannequins that hang in windows, that cast their shadows on our mortal flesh. I say no again and again, no thank you, I couldn’t, I can’t, I got my last csn allowance a month ago.

The light is slightly too yellow. Tinted with old foam and furniture seats.
Remember that instagram account that had the seats of different trains, metros and other collective transportation.[4] At 11:00, I was noting the triangles on the seats and if I

[2] Pierre Huyghe. (2014). *Untitled (Human Mask)* [Film/installation artwork]. Anna-Lena Films; Hauser & Wirth.

[3] Nirvana. (1991). *Lithium*. On *Nevermind* [Album]. DGC Records.

[4] @idontgiveaseat. (n.d.). *Idontgiveaseat* [Instagram profile]. Instagram. https://www.instagram.com/idontgiveaseat/ (Accessed: April 2 2026)

would have taken a photo I would choose the one where there is a skateboarder in action jumping a line.

My brother drinks milk and eats crackers whilst we watch a tractor with intense eyes drive around a farm. Brother says he is that tractor, I say I am the horse. He says I am the lighter of the two horses in frame. Brother says that he is hungry mom asks what he wants, he says: *to cuddle with Sara*.

I'm debating taking a shower, but the water feels too far away and a wet body is so hard to deal with. I fear I might bite my nails.

The Instrument

There tend to be themes of older objects pre-1990, usually more intricately made instruments, scissors and different tools. Older woodgrain, furniture from the midcentury. Cameras, audio and film equipment that pre-live me. Once I had the thought that using tools that came before my time could see something I could not or measure something I could not. They have experienced time before me, hence by nature have observed time outside my own. Perhaps they could then capture something outside me and the time I am in? I was continuously searching for this meaning behind everything I did and every choice I made. I used words like witchcraft, energy, aura, spirit, ghost, other, intuition. But in the end it ended up being so much simpler. I am not certain of the whys. I feel the whys by themselves dull down the actual craft and process and intensity of the journey. You don't walk into a church sermon without something taking place inside you. Certain moments, places, rooms and objects give different responses. I am only showing the readings of my instrument. Liv Bugge mentions the idea of active listening in her book Structural magic.[5] She discusses how the process of active listening is not only through the ears but through everything we encounter during a moment, all information gathered is of importance. If you notice a thought, a change in body temperature or a song that gets stuck in your head, all is information continuously or subconsciously connected to the active listening.

When playing percussion in an orchestra there are a few things to pay attention to. The conductor, the rest of the percussionists and the orchestra as a whole. Rarely do you have to pay attention to a singular working part of the ensemble but rather the whole. The conductor gives dynamics and tempo and the percussion becomes the engine behind it all, to make sure we keep on moving steady and on beat. In a percussion ensemble without a conductor each and everyone is the anchor and active listening becomes the primary source of dynamics. Each person is listening to each other, making sure not to overstep in volume or tempo, lifting each other up by listening and responding. When a musician really listens to the music they can become one with the other players of an ensemble and when the music is in harmony with the player themselves you become one. If I were to explain how I make what I make and how my practice looks to you now I would say I am a listener. My nerve endings go slightly further outside my body, my antennae are vibrating whilst my nose sniffs its surroundings. I was taught a version of active listening in music when I was nine. This idea has remained one of the biggest tools I use in creating. The primary thing is to listen, not only with ears but also with eyes, body and soul; reaction, intuition and gut feeling. Now the words active listening came to me late in this process, before I used gut feeling, intuition, reading, listening, collecting etc. But the major thing that is taking

[5] Bugge, L. (2022). *Structural magic*. Torpedo Press.

place is a sort of scanning of a space and actively listening to it and to myself, reading the room and jotting down the things that I encounter. What I actively do is feeling, sensing, capturing, collecting, writing, making soundscapes, gathering, placing, composing. Positioning myself as an instrument I read my surroundings and these readings continuously or subconsciously are jotted down in numerous ways. They are the first and last empty papers torn from old books that I type and pin to my wall. They are the hundreds upon hundreds of field recordings in my hard drive, they are the boxes full of objects and the systems I create. It's the preparation before a scene is shot; making sure the moment of capturing is true to me. A big sigh, a tuning into my own body, measuring the energy around me and adding a layer of calm over the scene. It is emotional tuning.

12 March
“The dreaded word,” Lisa says. “Yes” I say, “nostalgia”.

For years now the word has hung on me like mist on a winter morning: nostalgia, and who am I to say no to it. There isn't a need to disagree, the work moves beyond me, my grandfather would see his old suitcase, possibly reminding him of a trip long ago, my mother would see the toy she bought me and my sister many moons ago, you see history, I see time passing and a desperation in trying to understand time as something outside the linear. This human need for a well curated lineup of what a life is is beyond me: birth, play, teenage dread, romance, white picket fences, a car, a dog, a baby and death. The linearity of time as we are taught is something continuously critiqued and reflected upon in the artworks. I agree that the works by themselves can be read as a desire for capturing the now, perhaps a desperation in never being able to stay in it. I am unsure. Time is present at all times, a grief for what has passed without living it. A need to capture and hold myself to the present. Like capturing butterflies just to let them die pinned up in a glass box. Life will never be there, they are mere fragments, deaths of something that once were alive. But there is also life in those fragments. Davey mentions in Index Cards how Benjamin (or perhaps Barthes she doubts) wrote about clocks in photographs with this idea that a picture is recording the exact moment it's being captured. Could it be captured by will or is it merely taken without consent? Is it living or desperately trying to get away? Is it dead or alive or both? I stay in the superposition where I feel I am doing no wrong capturing these moments of time. They are both screaming to be let free and sparkling in their present and our past. So if one can be nostalgic for time itself then yes, I am nostalgic but as Barthes said “For me the noise of Time is not sad”.[6]

Around six years ago a philosophizing around what and most importantly why I liked certain things started. It first came about with an audio piece of multiple other favorite parts of other songs edited together. I knew I had preferences and favorites and I started to collect them, write them down in order to sort them out, order them in a line and

[6] Barthes, R. (1980). *Camera lucida: Reflections on photography*. Hill and Wang.

perhaps try to find some answers. There was a slight pattern in materials and methods and a clear way when using physical objects to see and sort out what I preferred. I found that different objects held different amounts of energy (a word that can refer back to both Benjamin's writings about the aura[7] of an object and to Bugge's active listening). I could with ease lay a line of six objects from least to most energy and so the *sorting* began. My first sorting #1 was a randomized assortment of objects from my studio at the time. Some thread, a pen, a rock, a needle etc. Six objects overall were placed in a line and then rearranged based on how the object felt, from least to most energy. The act itself was surprisingly easy and the rock came out first in line. The sorting had nothing to do with what the objects were but how they felt, not by touch, but by active listening. I was interacting with them, holding and moving them, but I never took their actual usage into consideration, it did not matter that a pen for instance symbolized something different compared to a piece of yarn. This way of sorting has continued since. With works like Sorting #6 I tried the act of sorting nine identical newly bought scissors from the same store. It took me about 10 minutes to sort, the longest to date, but there was still a way of feeling the objects and placing them into a line of least to most important. The ease with which I managed to do this with any objects, new, old, similar or completely other was fascinating. How? What is it that I actually am doing? There tends to exist a personal preference of course, an intuition of sorts that continuously or as within the sorting subconsciously comes into play. I compare it to lets say a favorite cup or spoon in the drawer. There is always a personal preference that we can or cannot tell why it is there. Perhaps the spoon is wider than the rest, more shiny, has good weight to it, or perhaps it's just because it feels good. The author Malcom Gladwell discusses these short moments of subconscious decisions in his book Blink[8] He calls it *thin slicing* and explains the term as “the ability of our unconscious to find patterns in situations and behaviour based on very narrow slices of experience” Gladwell's way of introducing thin slicing continues:Thin-slicing is not an exotic gift. It is a central part of what it means to be human. We thin-slice whenever we meet a new person or have to make sense of something quickly or encounter a novel situation. We thin-slice because we have to, and we come to rely on that ability because there are lots of hidden fists out there, lots of situations where careful attention to the details of a very thin slice, even for no more than a second or two, can tell us an awful lot. Gladwell discusses this innate knowledge we all contain. Based on biases, previous experiences and subconscious preferences, it is however not important to explain the hows and whys “Our world requires that decisions be sourced and footnoted, and if we say how we feel, we must also be prepared to elaborate on why we feel that way.... We need to respect the fact that it is possible to know without knowing why we know and accept that — sometimes — we’re better off that way”

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[7] Benjamin, W. (1969). *The work of art in the age of mechanical reproduction*. In H. Arendt (Ed.), *Illuminations* (H. Zohn, Trans., pp. 217–251). Schocken Books.

[8] Gladwell, M. (2005). *Blink: The power of thinking without thinking*. Little, Brown and Company.

The Observer

Centerstage.
A child approximately 1 year old and a woman sit at a kitchen table. The woman holds up a blanket in front of her and lowers it.

- peekaboo

The child laughs and claps its hands. She lifts the blanket in between her and the child once more. The child wonders, ”Where did she go?”

- peekaboo

The child laughs and claps

Stage left.
The child, now older, sits alone at the table, with two objects placed there. One red ball and one blue mug. The child puts the blue mug over the red ball.

- The ball exists even if I can not see it

The child lifts the cup

- The ball exists because I see it

Stage right.
Schrödinger:

- You see, if the cat is in superposition, it is both alive and dead at the same time. We can not observe what has taken place inside the box, hence we cannot make the conclusion that the cat is either dead or alive; it is both.[9]

The camera turns to the audience
The curtains on the stage close
The audience clap.

[9] Erwin Schrödinger, “Die gegenwärtige Situation in der Quantenmechanik,” *Naturwissenschaften* 23, No. 49 (1935): 807–812.

Between 0 and 2 years of age a child develops what's called *object permanence*. Object permanence is when the child understands that just because something isn't visible doesn't mean it disappears from the world.[10] Before object permanence though it seems to the child that the object simply disappears. That is why when you go 'peekabo' the child usually is happy, mommy is back in reality once again. Let's rephrase: Before object permanence is developed you can not know that something is there if you can't observe it. The world is based purely on your observation and you do not know if the world is the same when you can't observe it. In Swedish Astrid Lindgren said it best in her book Ronja Rövardotter[11] "syns inte finns inte" Loosely translated to " if not visible it doesn't exist". When we have developed this perception of understanding that the probability of an object staying in our reality (even if we can't observe it) is high, we never go back, even though we can not know for certain that it isn't actually gone. Probability is high, but scientifically there is a likelihood, even if slight, that the object can be gone or at least changed. It could in theory be anything and everything and nothing at all, all at the same time, this is called superposition. The cat is both dead and alive at the same time. The coined phrase object permanence would have us believe that we know and can trust our observation almost to a fault. But it is governed by a multitude of rules and fragile nerve endings. According to NASA, as much as 95% of our known universe is dark energy and dark matter.[12] That means that the universe we observe is a mere 5% and even that is full of unexplainable, unexplored or unknown parts.

The concepts that govern our understanding of reality are loosely woven threads of yarn that wouldn't stand a flame. Yet we keep on weaving. We have created all sorts of systems and rules and religions in order to get closer to truth and we keep on searching for the theory of everything. These tendencies to give in to the human-made system seem easier than to question our observation at every step. It could drive you mad having to question your reality every second of every day, to be trapped in this body of flesh with a brain telling you how you experience life and never be able to escape beyond it, but no matter how hard we try we can not know the unknown. So we systemize and collect, form made-up structures and experiments to sort and categorize what we are doing in hopes that it can bring us closer to some form of truth, and in my case, some form of artistic truth. Perhaps that's why Gladwell's thoughts on the whys are so important. I can not exit the system I was born into, but I can examine and critique it based on my own observation because of the fact that I am experiencing it. I thin-slice and listen, I have subconscious preferences and feelings beyond my own comprehension and the fact that I have them is proof enough that they are important.

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[10] Jean Piaget, *The construction of reality in the child* (New York: Basic Books, 1954), 76–85.

[11] Astrid Lindgren, *Ronja Rövardotter* (Stockholm: Rabén & Sjögren, 1981).

[12] Jeanette Kazmierczak, "Dark matter," *NASA*, https://science.nasa.gov/universe/dark-matter/ (Accessed: April 2 2026)

... That direction, that's where you should look.

I point into the air and say:

> By seeing what is here you can imagine everything that isn't and by knowing what you do observe you acknowledge everything you do not.

Bark Bark

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